my Service shall remain unstinted.

I hope that you will accept my application at the earliest.

Sincerely,

Dr Kiran Bedi

After glancing through the application, he put it aside and instead reminded me of what all he had to contend with.

He recalled his personal forbearance in facing a vicious tirade when he was under consideration as the ruling party's candidate for the post of the president of India (which later went to a woman candidate). The Opposition parties as well as those supporting the government had ganged up together to label him as a failure.

I sensed this was not the time for me to insist on my decision. He said that my being overlooked for the post of Delhi's police commissioner was a decision not in his hands. I had not forgotten that he had said this earlier too.

A thought flashed in my mind that I should hold on. I thanked the home minister for his time and then said: 'Sir, I will return to work.'

As I stepped out of North Block, which houses the Ministry of Home Affairs, I suddenly saw hordes of media persons descending on me from apparently nowhere. Evidently, they were waiting for me to emerge from the building. Perhaps, there had been a leak somewhere. They thought the decision (on the appointment of Delhi's police commissioner) was being reviewed. They asked me as to what exactly had happened. I replied: 'I am returning to work.' (Fortunately, they did not ask me for how long. Only I knew the answer!)

I, along with some colleagues, now began preparations for our organization's annual day, which was close by. We had made some interesting preparations, perhaps first of their kind.

As the days passed by and the 'controllers' thought I had reconciled myself to my situation, they started to pass on more work to my organization, which was merely clerical in nature and monotonously repetitive like writing police mission reports, which would only add to the shelves of the office.

I now decided to leave, but on my terms …

I put in my papers. I just sent in my request for voluntary retirement to the home secretary, this time through the normal channel of correspondence without seeking any appointment.

I timed my request for release in such a way that the last day of my duty would be the one following the annual day event. One last responsibility fulfilled towards the bureau.

* * *

At long last, it was time for me to say goodbye to my service but only in this birth. For, if reborn and with the same parents, I will be back, but with one very strong conviction: I will strive to lead the Indian Police, nationally, as India's home minister. For that is the seat of responsibility from where police, prison and criminal justice reforms emanate.

India will then become a befitting example as the largest and safest democracy that guarantees security to all, irrespective of status or gender.